Jang. While the Tactical HQ of 4 Division was set up at Dirang Dzong, sixty-four kilometres southeast of Se-la, 4 Artillery Brigade set itself up at the well-appointed officers' mess in Jang which had a telecommunications link with Dirang Dzong and a spectacular view of the Geyshe-la and Mukdang-la forward slopes.

As per 4 Division's assessment of the situation the previous day, the Chinese should have been snapping at the heels of the withdrawing Indians. Accordingly, Charlie Company of 4 Garhwal Rifles under Major Rai was given the task of holding Jang till last light on 24 December. The Engineers had prepared Bridge 4 for demolition while a twenty-man patrol base was established to keep a lookout for any Chinese activity.

'THE TWANG OF A BOW STRING'

Just before dawn, Chinese mortars began their morning bombardment of both Tenglong-la and Milaktong-la while the infantry started closing in on the Indian positions. Strewn amidst the rocks were a number of the dead, as well as those who grievously wounded, a grim reminder of the fierce fighting that had occurred the previous day. However, to the surprise of the Chinese, there was no retaliatory fire from the Indian artillery guns that had played havoc with their troops the previous day. Gradually the mortars stopped firing and probing patrols moved even closer to the Indian defences. Bunker after bunker, position after position, were all vacant. By first light, the Chinese realized that they had captured Bum-la in its entirety, and that the road to Tawang was wide open below them.

On Chinese maps, Milaktong-la is referred to as Dongmen-la. After finding it abandoned, four companies (equivalent to four Indian battalions) of the 3rd Regiment began to cautiously descend towards Tawang. Signs of the hurried departure of the Indians were everywhere; most attempts to burn abandoned equipment had not been very successful, only creating a pall of smoke from smouldering fires. Chinese troops closing in from the direction of Lum-la and by the direct route from Zimithang now found the tracks ahead of them wide open and the advance elements entered Tawang almost simultaneously. No wonder then that the Chinese version of the battle says rather sardonically:

> To the north of Tawang there is high ground, thus it is easy to defend and towards the south is the Tawang river valley, which allows one to look down from a commanding height. Thus from a military point of view, the tactical location is extremely significant. The commander of